

that frustrated before.”

Djokovic, who had easily ousted young Czechs 24th-seeded Jiri Lehecka and 26th-seeded Tomas Machac before eliminating Alcaraz, certainly still had the game to do the same against Zverev if he weren't injured.

But his left thigh was wrapped in tape covered by white strapping, and he hadn't practised except for a few minutes before the intriguing semifinal. With Djokovic leading Zverev 4-3 in the first set, a concerned Patrick said, “He looks 75 per cent of his maximum.”

Would that be anywhere near enough against Zverev? The plot thickened when Djokovic didn't run for Zverev's forehand winner that evened the score at 6-all. Was the canny 37-year-old saving energy for the tiebreaker or was he in too much pain to run?

At 3-4 in the tiebreaker, Djokovic smacked a 197 kph ace. Then came a beautiful backhand drop shot followed by a diabolical topspin lob winner over the towering Zverev for 5-4. A jubilant Djokovic fan raised a sign saying, “Keep calm and the GOAT is back.”

Not so fast. Djokovic's backhand slice floated out for 5-5, and Zverev's bold forehand winner put him ahead 6-5. Djokovic dictated the next point and moved forward but surprisingly missed a routine forehand volley, conceding the tiebreaker 7-5.

Djokovic then stunned the crowd and Zverev when he immediately walked to the umpire and retired. “Game, set, and match, Zverev” — came the announcement. A small number of fans unfairly booed.

Zverev came to his defence in his on-court interview with Jim Courier: “Don't boo a player when he goes out with an injury. There's no guy I respect more than Novak... He's won this tournament 10 times... I played him in 2021 when he had an abdominal tear and he served 28 aces.”

At his press conference, Djokovic elaborated: “I did everything I could to manage the muscle tear. Unfortunate ending, but I tried. It was getting worse and worse. I kept



feeling more and more pain... Injury is the biggest enemy of a professional athlete.”

In the other semifinal, Sinner faced 21st seed Ben Shelton, the high-energy American with a high-octane lefty serve. Sinner had held serve 96 per cent of the time in five prior matches. So, Shelton raised hopes for a huge upset when he broke serve in the opening game and 11th game to serve for the set at 6-5. Somewhat rattled, Sinner had to fend off two set points, forcing a tiebreaker.

Reckless forehand errors undid the American and Sinner seized the tiebreaker 7-2 and never looked back in his predictable 7-6 (2), 6-2, 6-2 victory. Shelton, coached by his father Bryan, a 1990s touring pro, is clearly a work in progress. His

Body over mind: A muscle tear forced Djokovic to retire in his semifinal against Zverev. GETTY IMAGES

backhand is a glaring weakness, his forehand is erratic, and his shot selection is often low percentage. “To make the top 10, Shelton has to improve his return of serve,” said former No. 1 Courier.

As for the superiority of Sinner, however, there is no doubt at all. You can take it first-hand from Zverev. “He's very, very similar to Novak when he was at his best,” Zverev said. “They barely miss. They make you think you have to overhit all the time to have a chance in a rally against them. It's very, very difficult to win a point from the back of the court against them.”